

Chapter 91_1 - Reunion

Ning Fuyi didn't bring much with her. In these thirty years, she had rarely left the Demon Realm. Each day, aside from diligently refining Ning Changfeng's immortal power, she would stay cooped up in the greenhouse tending to the flowers. Only when demons occasionally came looking for trouble would she go out to fight.

Initially, she would encounter some powerful and troublesome demons that required her and Jiuying to handle together, and she often ended up severely injured and bloodied. But as time passed and Ning Changfeng's immortal power gradually merged with her immortal meridians, she was injured less and less frequently.

Until five years ago, when she had refined most of the cultivation within her body and was about to break through to the Void Comprehension Realm approaching the Great Vehicle Realm¹, she fought for three days and nights against a notorious tyrant and finally slayed him in the wilderness.

Since then, demons and monsters within a radius of hundreds or thousands of li² all kept their respectful distance from her. More and more sought refuge in the demon cave, and Ning Fuyi, as promised, granted them protection and taught them all the demonic arts she had learned in her previous life, greatly increasing their magical power.

After that, no one dared approach the demon cave even one step.

However, for some unknown reason, her cultivation growth had stagnated since five years ago. No matter how she cultivated, she couldn't break through. But with the Emei Thorn at her side, her strength definitely exceeded that of others at the same realm, so she didn't worry too much about cultivation levels and continued to practice daily, seeking growth through techniques.

Now she could finally enter her consciousness sea and examine the two trees within it. The normal one had withered considerably, with only a few fruits remaining, representing the immortal power that had yet to be refined.

As for the demon tree, although the seal Chu Qingqiu had planted had been breached slightly, it was still relatively intact.

When Ning Fuyi said she would leave, she truly meant it. Half an hour later, she was already standing beneath the demon cave's great hall that nearly pierced the heavens.

Although so many years had passed, her important belongings were still carried on her person as usual, so aside from some gold and silver trinkets, there wasn't much to pack.

The gardenia flower was carefully placed in a crystal box and safely stored in her prayer bead.

"Shang Qiu³." She called out, and the red-eyed demon clan member emerged from black smoke, bowing and placing his hand on his left shoulder in the demon clan's salute.

"I have urgent matters and must leave the Demon Realm. If things go quickly, I may return in three to five days. If slowly, I don't know how long it will take. During this time, I must trouble you to manage the demon cave well."

"If there's an urgent matter, use this to find me." Ning Fuyi handed him a green feather, which Shang Qiu respectfully accepted.

"This subordinate will certainly guard the demon cave for the Demon Lord and await the Demon Lord's return," Shang Qiu said with lowered head.

Ning Fuyi nodded at him, then turned to look at Jiang Li, who was being supported by Xi Que⁴, her voice becoming gentler: "Medical Immortal Jiang, you're already weak from testing medicines. This journey will surely involve long-distance travel, so there's no need to trouble the Medical Immortal to come along."

"Xi Que, you must properly accompany Medical Immortal Jiang during her recovery."

Xi Que clasped her hands together and nodded: "Yes."

"What about me? What about me?" Han Ya⁵ poked her head forward, but when Ning Fuyi looked at her, she shrank back.

"You—leaving you anywhere would just cause trouble. Better to take you with me so I can watch that you don't create any incidents." Ning Fuyi said indifferently.

Upon hearing this, Han Ya nearly jumped up with joy, but meeting Ning Fuyi's gaze, she forced herself to calm down.

"Alright, let's go." Ning Fuyi patted Bai Lin's⁶ head, and Bai Lin immediately soared into the air, his body growing massive as he excitedly wagged his head and tail.

Jiuying was the first to leap onto Bai Lin's back. When Ning Fuyi was about to mount, Jiang Li called out to her.

"Young Master, I must remind you of something. The Divine Venerable is now missing one earthly spirit⁷, so she will definitely be different from ordinary people. You need to prepare yourself mentally. Moreover, if the soul has already found a host, you cannot forcibly separate it from the host—that would violate the natural order. Not only would you suffer divine retribution, but the Divine Venerable might also suffer backlash."

"You can only wait for the natural course of life and death, then use the Soul-Chasing Candle to guide the soul back into the flower."

Jiang Li spoke very solemnly, so Ning Fuyi listened carefully and nodded to show she understood, then turned and transformed into points of light, flying onto Bai Lin's back.

One person, one bird, and two divine beasts left the Demon Realm just like that. Jiang Li watched the increasingly blurred white tiger silhouette in the dark clouds for a long time without looking away.

Xi Que beside her carefully supported her arm and said gently: "Medical Immortal Jiang, let's go too."

Jiang Li nodded, her sparkling eyes curving as she smiled: "Tell me, what exactly are your master's feelings toward the Divine Venerable?"

Xi Que looked puzzled. She shook her head and answered evasively: "This subordinate doesn't often hear the master speak of the Divine Venerable, nor do I know what kind of person the Divine Venerable is."

"But someone who can make the master yearn for decades, watering with tears every day, must be extremely wonderful."

Jiang Li said nothing, but looked at her with curved red lips and smiled: "You're much cleverer than that little crow. Then let me ask you something—do you demons have any way to become human?"

Xi Que blinked and thought hard, then finally shook her head: "We were born as demons. Among demon folk, aside from those who commit evil, there are none who don't want to become human."

"This subordinate has taken form for many years but has never heard of any demon clan being able to become human."

Hearing this, Jiang Li lowered her head with a hint of disappointment in her expression, though it was quickly covered by a smile.

"Let's go," she said.

The demon cave was located in the westernmost Western Wasteland, but the Soul-Chasing Candle consistently pointed southeast. After Ning Fuyi's group traveled for two days, the scenery below changed from towering peaks to plains covered in green fields, and only then did the Soul-Chasing Candle finally change direction.

"It seems we've arrived." Jiuying, who had been holding the Soul-Chasing Candle and dozing, suddenly opened her eyes and called out as if startled awake.

Ning Fuyi instantly appeared before her and called softly to Bai Lin, who then hung in the air with his legs dangling.

The candle flame that had been pointing southeast was now drifting northward. Ning Fuyi urgently called: "Bai Lin, go back."

After retreating about several zhang⁸, the Soul-Chasing Candle's flame finally returned to its original position with gentle swaying.

Ning Fuyi immediately felt her palms covered with sweat. She had never been this nervous in her entire life.

She didn't know where that soul was located, whether it had found a host, and if it had a host, whether that host was human or some kind of spirit creature.

If it was human, she didn't know if it was male or female, old or young.

Jiuying seemed to sense her nervousness. She lowered her hand to put away the Soul-Chasing Candle, poked her head out to look down, and pretended to ponder: "Ning Fuyi, look—below there are wine flags fluttering and flower boats on blue waves. It looks like a mortal realm town in Jiangnan⁹."

"It seems the Divine Venerable might have been born as a mortal. But now that thirty years have passed, the Divine Venerable wouldn't already be... thirty years old, would she?"

Ning Fuyi's palms tightened as she looked down following her gaze: "What if she's thirty? As long as she's still there, even if she was reborn as a mountain sprite, it wouldn't matter."

"Oh." Jiuying squinted with a smile. "Since that's the case, shall we go down?"

So after the time it takes for an incense stick to burn, the three of them appeared in the town's back alleys, blending in with the passing citizens.

To avoid attracting attention, they all concealed their auras and changed into ordinary clothing. Ning Fuyi still wore black, but her magnificent magic-patterned heavenly silk dress was replaced with ordinary dark-colored wide-sleeved robes, with the lower garment reaching her ankles. When she let her hands hang down, it made her waist appear even more slender.

Her hair was bound with a dragon bone hairpin, leaving a handful of black silk behind her. Her rather cold features paired with the dark colors made her alluring yet still intimidating.

Jiuying wore an entire outfit of heavenly silk red dress. When her shoulders and waist swayed, the silk moved with her like fish swimming in water.

"Master, why has the Soul-Chasing Candle gone out?" Han Ya asked anxiously, cupping her hands around the candle and trying to make it light up.

"It proves that the person we're looking for is in this town." Ning Fuyi looked around. "It's just that this town is so large, we don't know where to find her."

"Who cares? At worst we'll stay here for a few dozen days and search through all the people, birds, flowers, and dogs until we find her." Jiuying had quite the optimistic attitude.

Ning Fuyi said nothing. She frowned in thought, then suddenly remembered something. She took the white tiger from her prayer bead and held it in her arms, using her wide sleeves to cover its tiger head, whispering: "Bai Lin made a blood contract with Chu Qingqiu. As long as Chu Qingqiu's soul hasn't scattered, it should be able to smell her scent."

Bai Lin didn't disappoint her. It suddenly let out a soft roar in her arms, its thick tail pointing straight east.

"It sensed her." Ning Fuyi suppressed the tremor in her voice and spoke softly.

After saying this, she hurried off, with Jiuying and Han Ya quickly following.

Ning Fuyi followed the direction Bai Lin pointed, walking farther and farther until she had left the town behind. The human habitation gradually thinned out, and spring scenery surrounded them. The river flowed like a green ribbon through wild flowers, with a river of misty water reflecting the clear sky, and gentle layered mountains under the blue vault of heaven.

When they saw two tea houses on either side of the official road, Bai Lin suddenly became agitated, desperately trying to break free from Ning Fuyi. Fearing it would startle the common people, Ning Fuyi quickly stuffed it back into her prayer bead.

"It suddenly became so excited—the Divine Venerable's soul must be here." Jiuying was also a bit nervous, discreetly observing the travelers sitting in the open-air tea houses.

"That's not right. These are all men. Could it be that the Divine Venerable became a broad-shouldered, thick-waisted big man in this life?" Jiuying shuddered as she spoke.

"Not necessarily, Master. There are still women sitting over there." Han Ya pointed to the tea house on the left, standing on her tiptoes.

"An elderly woman in her sixties and a young child—which one do you think would be the Divine Venerable?" Jiuying pursed her lips.

Ning Fuyi was so confused by their chatter that her heart was in chaos. She didn't linger and found a seat, beckoning to the shopkeeper: "One pot of tea."

"One pot of spring tea," the shopkeeper said lazily.

"Master, don't worry. I'll ask each one for you!" Han Ya said, shaking her head from side to side. Before Ning Fuyi could speak, she had already taken Ning Fuyi's tea and sat down in the middle of a group of bare-chested men who had returned from work.

"You little crow really aren't afraid of dealing with people. Your mouth is so glib—you're not like a crow at all, more like a magpie."

"She's been like this since childhood." Ning Fuyi had just finished speaking when she looked up to see that Han Ya had already put her leg up on the bench, spitting as she talked and addressing the big men as brothers.

Ning Fuyi and Jiuying: ...

After about the time it takes for an incense stick to burn, Han Ya returned triumphantly and plopped down.

"After infiltrating for so long, what did you find out?" Jiuying asked helplessly.

"I even found out what their ancestors' grandfathers were called." Han Ya smugly tossed her hair. "Master, these people are all ordinary country folk with no signs of missing an earthly spirit. Did that big bug's nose malfunction and smell wrong?"

"No way. Bai Lin made a contract with Chu Qingqiu for so long—he would never smell wrong." Ning Fuyi stood up. "Let's look around this area. Maybe she's just not in this tea house."

Maybe it's a flower or a blade of grass nearby.

When the three of them stood up, the big men nearby waved at Han Ya: "Little sister, it's getting dark, and the town hasn't been peaceful lately with frequent bandits. You girls traveling at night isn't safe—why not stay in town for a day!"

"Thank you, big brother!" Han Ya turned and cupped her fists toward them.

Ning Fuyi glanced at them, then turned to leave, but her heart suddenly skipped a beat. She immediately stopped in place, her heartbeat rapidly accelerating with that sudden flutter.

"Master?" Han Ya tilted her head to ask.

Ning Fuyi raised her hand to signal her not to speak, then slowly turned around. A pale green figure suddenly burst into her vision.

It was a young woman with three thick layers of veil firmly covering her face. She was carrying a huge basket that didn't match her thin body, gesturing at the shopkeeper.

"Go, go, go! Just a few liang¹⁰ of broken tea, giving you these copper coins is already generous. If you don't want them, give them back!" The shopkeeper was full of impatience and reached to snatch the copper coins from the woman's hands. The woman quickly stepped back, protecting the coins.

"Heh." Seeing this, the shopkeeper waved his hand. "Fine, fine. Take the coins and leave quickly. Don't delay my business!"

"That person is too wicked! I'll go teach him a lesson!" Han Ya rolled up her sleeves and was about to step forward, but Jiuying grabbed her.

"The person hasn't gone far yet. If you interfere now, what if he retaliates against her later? If you want to vent your anger, wait until she's gone far away—then you can beat him however you want." Jiuying pulled Han Ya aside and gave her advice. "You're still too young."

Ning Fuyi wasn't listening to their conversation. She stood there dumbfounded, her heart feeling like it was about to jump out, her feet seeming rooted to the ground.

Thirty years of waiting were finally coming to an end. More than thirty years of longing reached their peak in this moment.

After being separated for so long, the resentment in her heart still existed, though it had faded somewhat. Now that the person appeared before her eyes like this, it felt like a dream, giving rise to a kind of fear.

Jiuying looked at the woman's retreating figure, then at Ning Fuyi's expression, and finally reacted: "Could it be that this woman is... the Divine Venerable?"

At this time, the big men drinking tea nearby also raised their heads: "What, do you know her?"

The equally stunned Han Ya picked up the conversation: "We don't know her. May we ask who she is? She looks quite pitiful."

"Indeed pitiful." One of the big men sighed. "This woman is called A Chou¹¹. It's said her appearance is too frightening and her personality is solitary and strange. Every time she goes out, she scares people, so she has to wear three layers of veil. At such an age, no one dares to marry her."

"Not only that, she was born deaf, can't hear, and can't speak." The man clicked his tongue twice. "Her parents died early, and she's been living alone all these years."

"Fortunately, she's intelligent and learned some lip reading, so she can barely understand what people are saying."

The more Ning Fuyi listened, the tighter her fists clenched, until she nearly drew blood. She didn't listen to more and followed behind the woman.

The woman walked unsteadily toward more secluded and deserted places, gradually leaving the hustle and bustle behind. The sky was also growing dark, with the setting sun sinking into the clouds.

But Ning Fuyi kept her brows tightly furrowed, her eyes dark, keeping her distance without moving forward even half a step.

"Master, why don't you go forward and recognize her?" Han Ya asked quietly, not understanding.

"You're being silly. That woman looks like a weak mortal and probably has no memories. If we just rush up like this, we'd definitely scare her badly." Jiuying said.

"But we can't just keep following like this. We need to find a way to talk to her!"

"Easier said than done." Jiuying's golden eyes turned in the orange-yellow sunlight, then she suddenly said, "How about this—Ning Fuyi, you pretend to be a passing beggar and ask her for some water to drink? Maybe she'll take pity on you and take you in?"

Ning Fuyi didn't respond, but Han Ya jumped up first: "No way! My master is the dignified Demon Lord! How can she pretend to be a beggar? If word gets out, those little demons would laugh at us!"

Jiuying pouted: "Then what do you suggest?"

"Don't the storybooks always talk about heroes saving beauties?" Han Ya blinked her black eyes. "How about I pretend to be a bandit and grab her, then Master pretends to be a passing hero and saves her from my clutches?"

Jiuying stroked her chin and nodded: "That's an idea. What do you think?"

Ning Fuyi was in such turmoil that she had no mind to indulge their nonsense. Just as she was about to shake her head, the prayer bead on her wrist suddenly expanded greatly. Before she could stop it, a white tiger with hanging eyes broke free from the prayer bead and charged out.

This tiger's roar nearly shattered the heavens. Birds took flight and wild beasts fled all around. Even the deaf woman ahead sensed something was wrong.

Ning Fuyi frantically tried to recall Bai Lin, but seeing its master, Bai Lin was too excited to care about her. Its four massive paws struggled violently, leaving Ning Fuyi disheveled with her black hair in disarray.

Just as the woman turned around in alarm and her gaze was about to fall on them, Jiuying and Han Ya immediately abandoned Ning Fuyi and dove into the prayer bead. Ning Fuyi cursed furiously in her heart but didn't dare delay. She desperately controlled Bai Lin and roughly stuffed it back in.

However, Bai Lin was really strong. Before disappearing, it kicked her in the face with one paw, sending Ning Fuyi tumbling. In her panic, she heard the woman's footsteps approaching.

When she looked up again, she met a pair of clear peach blossom eyes¹². The owner of those eyes was making gestures at her chest, as if asking if she was hurt.

The moment she saw those peach blossom eyes, Ning Fuyi's mind went completely blank.

Then she closed her eyes, pillowed her head on her arm, and "weakly" "fainted" to the ground.

Footnotes:

¹ **Void Comprehension Realm approaching the Great Vehicle Realm** (通虚逼近大乘): Higher cultivation realms in this world's system.

² **Li** (里): A traditional Chinese unit of distance, approximately 500 meters or 0.3 miles.

³ **Shang Qiu** (商仇): A character's name meaning "Commercial Vengeance."

⁴ **Xi Que** (喜鹊): Means "Magpie," one of Ning Fuyi's bird-spirit subordinates.

⁵ **Han Ya** (寒鸦): Means "Cold Crow," another of Ning Fuyi's bird-spirit subordinates.

⁶ **Bai Lin** (白麟): The white tiger that serves as Chu Qingqiu's contracted spirit beast.

⁷ **One earthly spirit** (一魄): Referring to the seven earthly spirits (七魄) in Chinese spiritual beliefs.

⁸ **Zhang** (丈): A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.3 meters.

⁹ **Jiangnan** (江南): The regions south of the Yangtze River, known for their scenic beauty and prosperity.

¹⁰ **Liang** (两): A traditional Chinese unit of weight for silver, approximately 50 grams.

¹¹ **A Chou** (阿丑): A name meaning "Ugly Girl."

¹² **Peach blossom eyes** (桃花眼): A term describing beautiful, charming eyes shaped like peach blossoms.